Although the exact geographical definition may differ between various countries—in part, a reflection of their national interests and geographies—there are some conceptual overlaps. Perhaps most significantly, the Indo–Pacific signifies a single strategic arena encompassing parts of the Indian and Pacific Ocean basins. It highlights the importance of the maritime domain for both commercial cooperation and strategic competition, although not necessarily at the expense of the continental sphere as some imagine it. By highlighting the Indian Ocean and widening the regional scope, the Indo–Pacific also elevates the role of India and highlights the importance of the country in the regional balance of power. By its size and geographical location, India is a geopolitical keystone in the Indian Ocean and derives advantages from its economic weight, its long coastline, and its blue water navy.

In sum, India's Act East Policy reflects the growing importance of security, a wider geographical scope, and greater urgency on New Delhi's part, compared to the prior Look East Policy. It highlights startegic shifts, the importance of the maritime domain and the regional balance of power. In practice, Acting East will require at least four interlocking lines of effort. First, India must act to secure the Indian Ocean region where military competition risks escalation, particularly given the importance of regional chokepoints and the growing interests and involvement of the world's major powers. Second, India must begin to play the role of a balancer—even if it is unlikely to be *the* balancer—to China in Southeast Asia. This will require Indian political and security engagement and stronger diplomatic and economic connections with Southeast Asia. Third, India must deepen strategic partnerships with like-minded and capable maritime powers who share India's concerns about China's rise, particularly the United States, Japan, and Australia: the Quad. But it must not neglect other relationships important to the Indo–Pacific balance of power, including Russia, European powers, South Korea, Taiwan, and others with important roles and capabilities. And fourth, India must manage its long-term competition with China, preserving stability without yielding on core Indian interests.